Country Profile: Lithuania

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholicism
- Official language: Lithuanian
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Lithuanians

Historical Background

Lithuania was incorporated into the Russian Empire in the 18th century. After World War I, Lithuania declared its independence in 1918, although the young state faced territorial disputes with Poland and difficulties in establishing a stable government. Lithuania became part of the Soviet Union in 1940, experienced Nazi occupation from 1941 to 1944, and was then brought back under Soviet control in 1944. On March 11, 1990, Lithuania declared the restoration of its independence, becoming the first Soviet republic to do so. However, it officially gained recognition as an independent state only in 1991, following the August coup d'etat in Moscow and the dissolution of the Soviet Union in December 1991.[1]

Groups

- **Lithuanians** are the core ethnic group speaking the Lithuanian language, and the majority of the group members adhere to Roman Catholicism. According to the official statistics, Lithuanians represent 84% of the total population.[2]

- **Poles** are the second-largest ethnic group in Lithuania, making up approximately 6.5% of the population.[3] Most members of this community speak Polish and practice Roman Catholicism. The majority of Poles in Lithuania reside in the Vilnius region. Their political interests are primarily represented by the Polish

[1] Eidintas et al., 2013.
[2] Official government statistics source, 2022.
[3] Ibid.

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Electoral Action Party, which has been actively demanding more political and cultural self-determination since Lithuania regained independence.[4]

- **Russians** are the third-largest ethnic group in Lithuania, comprising 5% of the population.[5] They primarily speak Russian and are followers of the Russian Orthodox faith, represented by the Lithuanian Orthodox Church. Although the Russian presence in Lithuania dates back to the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth, the large influx of Russians occurred during the Soviet era due to the transmigration policies of the USSR.
- **Belarusians** have a historical presence in Lithuania, dating back to their important political role in the Grand Duchy of Lithuania during the Middle Ages.[6] However, a significant influx occurred after 1940, following Soviet transmigration policies. Today, Belarusians make up about 1% of the population, mainly concentrated in Vilnius and along the Lithuanian-Belarusian border.[7] During the Soviet period, Belarusians were largely assimilated into a Russian-speaking identity, resulting in widespread Russian-Belarusian bilingualism. They predominantly adhere to the Russian Orthodox faith, which is represented by the Lithuanian Orthodox Church, a diocese of the Russian Orthodox Church.[8]

State Profile

Official Language

The official state language of Lithuania is Lithuanian, according to Article 14 of the 1992 Lithuanian Constitution.

Official Religion

Lithuania has no official state religion. Article 40 of the 1992 Constitution establishes the secular character of teaching in state and municipal establishments. However, the majority in Lithuania identify as Roman Catholics. Freedom of religion is guaranteed by the Lithuanian Constitution, allowing people to practice their faiths freely.

Education Policies

In Lithuania, compulsory education lasts until the age of 16, covering primary and lower secondary education. The education system is structured into several stages: pre-

[4] Sambanis et al., 2018; Minority Rights, 2015c.
[5] Official government statistics source, 2022.
[6] Minority rights, 2015a.
[7] Ibid.
[8] The Diocese of Vilnius and Lithuania, 2024.

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primary education, which becomes mandatory at age 5; primary education, which spans grades 1 to 4; and lower secondary education, covering grades 5 to 10. Upper secondary education lasts one to two years. The educational system is decentralized, with responsibility shared among national institutions, municipalities, and educational institutions. The Seimas (Parliament) defines education policy, while the Ministry of Education, Science, and Sport implements it.[9] Private schools in Lithuania operate with considerable freedom within the legislative framework, as established by the Educational Act of 1991.[10,11]

Language Education Policies

In Lithuania, the Education Act (1991) establishes Lithuanian as the primary medium of instruction in schools. Lithuanian language education is compulsory throughout all levels of schooling, ensuring that students attain proficiency in reading, writing, and speaking. Lithuania supports the right of ethnic minorities to receive education in their native languages, following Article 30 of the Education Act (1991). Throughout 1991–2020, schools in areas with significant minority populations could offer instruction in Polish, Russian, Belarusian, and other minority languages.[12] Minority language schools follow the national curriculum but include additional classes in the native languages.

Religious Education Policies

The Constitution of Lithuania guarantees freedom of religion and belief, allowing individuals to practice and propagate their faiths freely. The education law provides for religious instruction in schools and ensures that students have the right to receive religious education according to their own or their parents' beliefs.

Religious instruction in Lithuanian public schools has been optional from 1992 to 2020, with students choosing between religious education and secular ethics courses.[13] The Law on Religious Communities and Associations, adopted in 1995, allows nine traditional religions to provide religious education in both public and private schools: Roman Catholicism, Greek Catholicism, Evangelical Lutheranism, Evangelical Reformed, Russian Orthodoxy, Old Believer, Judaism, Sunni Islam, and Karaite.[14] These traditional

[9] Eurydice, 2024.
[10] Education Act, 1991.
[11] Compedium, 2019.
[12] Education Act, 1991.
[13] Pranevičienė and Margevičiūtė, 2012.
[14] Republic of Lithuania, 1995. Law on Religious Communities and Associations of the Republic of Lithuania.

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religious communities are authorized to teach their religion in schools, with curricula approved by the Ministry of Education, Science, and Sport.

Bans and Restrictions

There are no language bans or restrictions in Lithuania. The media, both print and electronic, can broadcast in any language, except those reserved for the Lithuanian state. According to Article 34 of the Law on Public Information (no. VIII-1905) of 2000, information can be disseminated to the public in Lithuanian or any other language. Lithuanian Radio and Television can also broadcast programs in minority languages based on the needs of the local population.[15]

Constitutions and Laws

The 1990 Provisional Basic Law, which served as Lithuania's interim Constitution following the declaration of independence, explicitly mentions Lithuanians in the preamble and in the citizenship policy outlined in Article 32.[16] It recognizes Lithuanian as the state language, and the state is also committed to the comprehensive development and teaching of the Lithuanian language while creating conditions for the use and development of the languages of ethnic minorities.[17] The constitution declares Lithuania as a secular state, ensuring religious liberty and freedom of conscience, particularly in the field of education.[18]

Similarly, the 1992 Constitution reaffirms Lithuanian as the official state language and continues to uphold the country's secular nature and religious freedom (Articles 26 and 40).[19] Subsequent amendments have not altered the language and religious provisions related to national minorities.

Citizenship Laws

Lithuanian citizenship law follows the principle of *ius sanguinis*, allowing individuals with Lithuanian ancestry, whether through their parents, grandparents, or great-grandparents, to claim Lithuanian citizenship. Citizenship may also be granted through naturalization.[20] The *ius soli* principle is limited only to children of permanent stateless residents of

[15] L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2024.
[16] The Provisional Basic Law of Lithuania, 1990.
[17] Ibid.
[18] Ibid.
[19] Constitution of Lithuania, 1992.
[20] Law on Citizenship, 2010.

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Lithuania or unknown parents. The law also provides for the restoration of citizenship for individuals of Lithuanian origin who left the country between 1940 and 1990, upon renouncing any other citizenship and providing evidence of their previous Lithuanian citizenship.[21]

The 1989 Law on Citizenship of the Lithuanian SSR established a "zero option" approach, which allowed almost all individuals who were legally permanent residents of Lithuania at the time of the law's enactment to obtain Lithuanian citizenship. This policy applied regardless of how those residents had come to live in Lithuania, distinguishing Lithuania from other Baltic states like Latvia and Estonia, which imposed stricter requirements for citizenship. Specifically, the law provided citizenship to those who had Lithuanian citizenship before 1940, their descendants, and those born or with familial ties in Lithuania, as long as they were not citizens of another state. A two-year window was given for permanent residents to choose their citizenship, after which they would be considered to have rejected Lithuanian citizenship if they did not apply. The only significant exclusion was Soviet military officers, who were not considered permanent residents and thus were not eligible for citizenship under this law.[22]

According to the 1991 Citizenship law, a person can become naturalized if they agree to give the oath to the Republic and fulfill the conditions of speaking the Lithuanian language, having a place of residence, having a place of employment, and demonstrating knowledge of the basic provisions of the Lithuanian Constitution.[23]

National Anthem(s)

The Lithuanian national anthem, "Tautiška giesmė" (The National Hymn) was composed by Vincas Kudirka, a prominent Lithuanian poet and physician. In 1991, "Tautiška giesmė" became the national anthem of Lithuania.

The lyrics of "Tautiška giesmė" speak passionately of love for the homeland, the courage of Lithuanian heroes, and the determination to uphold national virtues and unity. They call on Lithuanians to draw strength from their history and traditions, to work together for the

[21] Kuris, 2009.
[22] Ibid.
[23] Law on Citizenship, 1991.

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common good, and to strive for a brighter future guided by light and truth. The lyrics include explicit references to ancestors, heroic deeds of the past, and national territory.[24]

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[24] Nationanthems.info, 2024.

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